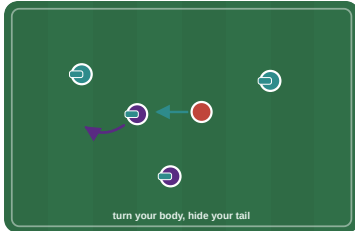




PROTECTING THE BALL

Shielding, and getting it back

SESSION PLAN



WARM-UP · OPTIONAL **Shield your tail** 10 min

Tails again: a pinnie tucked in the back like a tail. This time the job is to protect yours. Use your body, turn away, and don't let chasers grab it, while you try to steal theirs. It's shielding without a ball, and it leads right into today's skill.

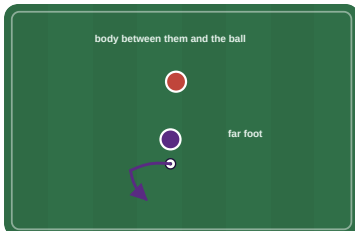
SAY IT SIMPLY "Body in the way!" · "Turn and hide it!" · "Back to the chaser!"



PLAY **Keep it, then get out** 15 min

Play this first, no coaching yet. 1v1 in a small square with an escape gate on each side. The player with the ball shields it for a few seconds, then tries to dribble out through either gate. The other player tries to win it back, staying on their feet. Swap and rotate often.

SAY IT SIMPLY "Shield it!" · "Now turn out!" · "Stay on your feet!"



PRACTICE **Shielding** 15 min

Now teach it: this fixes what just came up in Play. Teach players to protect the ball with their body: get side-on, arm out for balance, and keep the ball on the foot furthest from the defender. A partner applies light pressure while the player shields for a few seconds, then rolls the ball away and dribbles out.

SAY IT SIMPLY "Body in the way!" · "Ball on the far foot!" · "Big and strong!"

PLAY **Small-sided play** 15 to 20 min

Bring the game back so it gets used. Even teams, 3v3 or 4v4 to small goals. Light coaching, let them play.

SAY IT SIMPLY "Protect your ball!"

WHY IT MATTERS

Shielding is how a young player keeps the ball when someone gets close, instead of panicking and kicking it away. The same game gives a gentle first taste of winning the ball back too, kept light and always on the feet.

HOW IT DEVELOPS

- | | |
|------------------|---|
| U7 to U8 | Shield the ball a little longer under real pressure, and roll it to the far foot to turn out. |
| U8 to U10 | Shielding buys time to lay the ball off. The light defending here grows into pressuring on the feet, without diving in. |